

Conscience Witness

doc-conscience-witness

Hamartiology · Conscience · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

breadth broad
directness direct
variants stable

Statement under examination

Conscience is a divinely-given internal witness to God's law that, though damaged by sin, accuses or excuses moral agents and renders all without excuse before God.

In plain language

The Greek word *syneidēsis* (συνείδησις), usually translated conscience, appears in twenty-eight verses across ten New Testament books, and its moral sense is steady: an inward faculty that watches a person's conduct and returns a verdict. The clearest proof is grammatical. In Romans 2:15 and again in Romans 9:1 Paul uses the same present participle (the ongoing-action form of the verb) of the verb to co-witness, *symmartyreō* (συμμαρτυρέω), with the word conscience, in a construction (called a genitive-absolute, a Greek pattern that names a noun plus participle as the surrounding circumstance) that puts conscience as the active subject of an ongoing testimony. This verb occurs only three times in the whole New Testament, all in Romans, and twice it is conscience doing the witnessing, so this is Paul's settled way of speaking, not a stray image. Romans 2:15 surrounds it with courtroom words, accusing (*katēgoreō*, κατηγορέω) and defending (*apologeomai*, ἀπολογέομαι), over a law that is written (*graptos*, γραπτός) on the heart (*kardia*, καρδιά). Romans 1:19-20 says what can be known of God is plain within people and concludes that they are without excuse (*anapologētos*, ἀναπολόγητος), a word built from the same defend-root as the defending function of conscience. The damage clause is equally clear from the words. Conscience can be good, thrust away (*apōtheomai*, ἀπωθέομαι), seared as with a hot iron (*kaustēriazō*, καυστηριάζω, a hapax, a word that occurs only once in the Bible), weak, defiled, or washed clean by the blood of Christ. Why then do careful readers still differ? The reason is in the vocabulary itself, not in church history. The word *syneidēsis* (συνείδησις) carries more than one attested sense (it is polysemous, that is, multi-meaning). Sometimes it means general awareness or self-perception, and sometimes it means specifically the moral conscience, and a standard lexicon (a scholarly Greek dictionary) notes the two senses run together and even records an old variant reading at one verse. So a reader can grant that conscience witnesses yet argue about how far its verdict should be trusted, since the same texts show it can be miscalibrated or silenced. That tension is about the reliability and scope of the witness, never about whether it testifies. On the testimony itself the words leave no real room, which is why the proposition stands as affirmed. The Hebrew canon supports the same idea by other words, using heart (*lev*, לב, and *levav*, לבב) for the inward monitor, as when Job says his heart does not reproach him.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H3824	לבב	levav	heart	
G0018	ἀγαθός	agathos	good	
G0126	αἰδιος	aidios	eternal	
G0299	ἄμωμος	amōmos	blameless	

G0379	ἀναπολόγητος	anapologētos	inexcusable	2
G0505	ἀνυπόκριτος	anupokritos	genuine	
G0517	ἀόρατος	aoratos	invisible	
G0626	ἀπολογέομαι	apologeomai	to defend oneself	10
G0683	ἀπωθέομαι	apōtheomai	to reject	6
G0772	ἀσθενής	asthenēs	weak	
G1110	γνωστός	gnōstos	acquainted with	16
G1123	γραπτός	graptos	written	1
G1484	ἔθνος	ethnos	Gentiles	
G2041	ἔργον	ergon	work	177
G2316	θεός	theos	God	
G2588	καρδία	kardia	heart	146
G2723	κατηγορέω	katēgoreō	to accuse	22
G2743	καυστηριάζω	kaustēriazō	to brand	1
G3140	μαρτυρέω	martureō	to testify	
G3392	μιαίνω	miainō	to stain	
G3435	μολύνω	molunō	to defile	
G3551	νόμος	nomos	law	200
G4828	συμμαρτυρέω	symmartyreō	to testify with	3
G4893	συνείδησις	syneidēsis	conscience	28

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

The Greek noun for conscience (συνείδησις, syneidēsis, G4893) occurs in 28 verses across ten New Testament books (John, Acts, Romans, 1 and 2 Corinthians, 1 and 2 Timothy, Titus, Hebrews, 1 Peter) with a stable moral sense of an internal faculty that observes and renders a verdict on conduct. The witness claim is grammatically explicit and doubly attested: Romans 2:15 and Romans 9:1 both use the present active participle (the ongoing-action verb form) for co-witness (συμμαρτυρούσης, symmartyrousēs, from G4828 meaning to co-witness) together with the word for conscience (συνειδήσεως, syneidēseōs) in a genitive-absolute construction (a Greek grammatical pattern where a noun-plus-participle pair gives the surrounding circumstance, here naming conscience as the active subject), and Romans 2:15 frames the act with the courtroom verbs accusing (κατηγορούντων, katēgorountōn, from G2723 to accuse) and defending (ἀπολογουμένων, apologoumenōn, from G0626 to defend or make a defense) over the law written in the heart (γραπτόν ἐν ταῖς καρδίαις, grapton en tais kardiais). Romans 1:19-20 places what is known of God within them (ἐν αὐτοῖς, en autois) and draws the conclusion that they are without excuse (ἀναπολόγητους, anapologēτους, from G0379 meaning without defense). The damage clause is also lexically secured. Conscience can be good (1 Timothy 1:5), thrust away (1 Timothy 1:19), seared (κεκαυστηριασμένων, kekaustēriasmenōn, in 1 Timothy 4:2), weak (1 Corinthians 8:7), defiled (Titus 1:15), or cleansed (Hebrews 9:14). The only genuine lexical slack is that the word for conscience (συνείδησις, syneidēsis) is polysemous (carries more than one meaning, here a general awareness sense alongside the moral-conscience sense) and the faculty is documented as fallible, which bears on its reliability but not on whether it witnesses.

Scripture

Rom.2.14 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1484 ἔθνος, G3551 νόμος

Force. Gentiles who do not possess the Law of Moses nevertheless by nature (φύσει, physei) do the things of the law and so are a law to themselves, establishing that moral knowledge operates apart from written revelation. OpenBible links this verse to Romans 2:12, Psalm 147:19, and Acts 17:30, tying Gentile moral capacity to the giving of the law and to general moral accountability.

Rom.2.15 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4893 συνείδησις, G4828 συμμαρτυρέω, G1123 γραπτός, G2588 καρδία

Force. The work of the law is written (γραπτόν, grapton, G1123, here a hapax adjective, a word occurring only once in the entire Bible, in A-ASN form, that is accusative singular neuter) in the hearts (ἐν ταῖς καρδίαις, en tais kardiais), and the conscience co-witnesses. The verb is the present active participle of co-witness (συμμαρτυρούσης, symmartyrousēs, G4828, in V-PAP-GSF form, a present active participle in the genitive singular feminine, which marks ongoing simultaneous action) standing in a genitive-absolute (a Greek grammatical pattern where the noun-plus-participle pair sets the surrounding circumstance) with the word for conscience (συνειδήσεως, syneidēseōs, in the from-or-of grammatical form), so the grammar names conscience as the explicit subject of an ongoing act of joint testimony. The reasonings (λογισμοί, logismoi) alternately accuse (κατηγορούντων, katēgorountōn, G2723) or defend (ἀπολογουμένων, apologoumenōn, G0626). This is the single most explicit lexical anchor for an internal witnessing faculty that prosecutes or defends moral action.

Rom.9.1 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4893 συνείδησις, G4828 συμμαρτυρέω

Force. Paul says his conscience co-witnesses with him in the Holy Spirit, using the identical form of co-witness (συμμαρτυρούσης, symmartyrousēs, G4828, V-PAP-GSF, a present active participle in the genitive singular feminine, indicating ongoing simultaneous action) with the word for conscience (συνειδήσεως, syneidēseōs, in the from-or-of grammatical form) in a genitive-absolute (the Greek pattern in which a noun-plus-participle pair frames the surrounding circumstance), exactly the Romans 2:15 construction. The witness verb co-witness (συμμαρτυρέω, symmartyreō) appears only three times in the New Testament (Romans 2:15, Romans 8:16, Romans 9:1), all in Romans, and twice with conscience, which makes the conscience-as-witness usage Paul's own settled idiom rather than a one-off metaphor.

Rom.1.19 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1110 γνωστός, G2316 θεός

Force. What can be known of God is manifest in them (φανερὸν ἐν αὐτοῖς, phaneron en autois), because God has shown it to them. The locative phrase within them (ἐν αὐτοῖς, en autois) places the knowledge inside the moral agent. OpenBible weights the Romans 1:19 and Romans 1:20 mutual link heavily (16 and 56 votes), and links the passage to Psalm 19:1 and Acts 14:16, confirming the general-revelation reading (the view that God makes himself known to all people through creation and conscience).

Rom.1.20 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0517 άόρατος, G0126 αἰδιος, G0379 ἀναπολόγητος

Force. God's invisible attributes are clearly perceived (καθορᾶται, kathoratai) from the creation, with the explicit purpose that they are without excuse (εἰς τὸ εἶναι αὐτοὺς ἀναπολογήτους, eis to einai autous anapologēτους). Without-excuse (ἀναπολόγητος, anapologēτος, G0379) occurs only twice, both in Romans (Romans 1:20 and Romans 2:1), and is built on the same defend root (ἀπολογ-, apolog-) as the defending function of conscience in Romans 2:15, so the witness that can defend is precisely the witness whose verdict leaves the suppressor with no defense. OpenBible links Romans 1:20 to Psalm 19:1, Psalm 8:3, and Psalm 33:6, anchoring the creation-witness arm in the Hebrew canon even though the term without-excuse (ἀναπολόγητος, anapologēτος) is New Testament only.

1Tim.1.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4893 συνείδησις, G0018 ἀγαθός, G0505 ἀνυπόκριτος

Force. The goal of the charge is love from a pure heart and a good conscience and a sincere faith (ἐκ καθαρᾶς καρδίας καὶ συνειδήσεως ἀγαθῆς καὶ πίστεως ἀνυποκρίτου, ek katharas kardias kai syneidēseōs agathēs kai pisteōs anypokritou). A good conscience is paired with a clean heart and an unhypocritical faith, indicating that the word for conscience (συνείδησις, syneidēsis) is a calibratable moral faculty whose state can be qualified as good.

1Tim.1.19 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4893 συνείδησις, G0683 ἀπωθέομαι

Force. Some, having thrust away (ἀπωσάμενοι, apōsamenoī, from the verb to thrust away ἀπωθέομαι, apōtheomai, G0683) a good conscience, have shipwrecked (ἐναυάγησαν, enauagēsan) their faith. The verb shows conscience can be actively rejected, confirming the damage-but-persistence pattern stated in the proposition.

Heb.9.14 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4893 συνείδησις, G0299 ἄμωμος

Force. The blood of Christ cleanses (καθαριεῖ, kathariei) the conscience from dead works to serve the living God. Conscience is presented as defiled and in need of cleansing, which presupposes that it persists in damaged form prior to that cleansing. OpenBible heavily links Hebrews 9:14 to Hebrews 10:22 (45 votes), where the conscience is sprinkled clean.

Job.27.6 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H3824 לבב

Force. Job says his heart (לִבִּי, lebabi) does not reproach him for any of his days, using the heart as an inward moral monitor that can accuse or acquit. The Hebrew canon carries the conscience function with the words for heart (לב, lev, and לבב, levav) rather than a dedicated term, which is why OpenBible links Romans 2:15 to Job 27:6 (6 votes). This shows the doctrine is conceptually cross-canonical (present across both Testaments) even though the specific noun for conscience (συνείδησις, syneidēsis) is New Testament only.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Rom.2.15	Gen.3.8	openbible	4
Rom.2.15	Rom.9.1	openbible	6
Rom.2.15	Titus.1.15	openbible	7
Rom.2.15	Job.27.6	openbible	6
Rom.2.14	Rom.2.12	openbible	9
Rom.1.20	Rom.1.19	openbible	56
Rom.1.20	Ps.19.1	openbible	42
Rom.1.19	Acts.14.16	openbible	18
1Tim.1.5	Ps.24.4	openbible	4
Heb.9.14	Heb.10.22	openbible	45

Complicating texts

1Cor.8.7 · addressed

Paul speaks of a weak conscience (συνείδησις ἀσθενής, syneidēsis asthenēs, where weak G0772 occurs 23 times) that is defiled (μολύνεται, molynetai, G3435) by eating food associated with idols. A textual footnote in the lexical apparatus (the editorial record of manuscript readings) even records an ancient variant reading custom (συνηθεία, synētheia) for conscience (συνειδήσει, syneidēsei) here, which underlines that the noun ranges across more than the strict moral sense. This complicates a reading of conscience as infallible but confirms the proposition: conscience is a real witness yet can be miscalibrated, exactly the damaged-by-sin clause under test.

1Tim.4.2 · addressed

The conscience can be seared (κεκαυστηριασμένων, kekaustēriasmenōn, from the verb to brand or cauterize καυστηριάζω, kaustēriazō, G2743, a hapax, that is a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), seared as with a hot iron. This is the strongest damage term applied to conscience in the canon and reinforces the damaged-by-sin qualifier. The faculty can be cauterized toward insensibility, yet the lexical category persists as the thing that has been seared.

Titus.1.15 · addressed

Both the mind (νοῦς, nous) and the conscience (συνείδησις, syneidēsis) of the defiled are themselves defiled (μεμιάνται, memiantai, from the verb to defile μιάνω, miainō, G3392). This complicates treating conscience as a reliable rule, but it does not negate its witnessing function. Paul still treats the defiled conscience as a real locus of moral disorder, which presumes it remains the faculty that registers right and wrong.

2Cor.4.2 · addressed

Here the word for conscience (συνείδησις, syneidēsis) carries the broader sense of awareness or self-perception (Paul commends himself to every person's conscience), a sense the standard lexicon (the standard scholarly Greek dictionary) lists separately from the strict moral-conscience sense. This polysemy (the word's carrying more than one meaning) is the chief lexical reason a reader could quibble over scope, but in the anchor verses Romans 2:15 and Romans 9:1 the moral sense is disambiguated by the witness verb and the accuse and defend pairing, so it does not weaken the verdict.

Concordance traversed

G4893, G4828, G3140, G2723, G0626, G0379, G1123, G1110, G2588, G3551, G2041, G2743, G0683, G0299, G0505, G0018, G0772, G3435, G3392

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

None of the anchor verses fall in the ingested ECM window (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants currently covers only 3 John in this project), so no published CBGM data (data from the Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, the editorial tool for tracing manuscript relationships) applies. The Romans 2:14 word-order marker for they-might-do (ἵποιοῦσιν, poiōsin) and the Hebrews 9:14 pronoun marker for our (ἡμῶν, hēmōn) are form and pronoun variants that do not touch the readings of conscience (συνείδησις, syneidēsis), co-witness (συμμαρτυρέω, symmartyreō), written (γραπτός, graptos), or without-excuse (ἀναπολόγητος, anapologētos), so the verdict holds across plausible readings.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. natural_law, covenant_theology, dispensationalism

analogia scripturae invoked

natural_law: affirms · Romans 2:14-15 is read as direct evidence of an internal moral knowledge available to all humans apart from special revelation. The genitive-absolute construction (the Greek grammatical pattern where a noun-plus-participle pair sets the surrounding circumstance) of the participle co-witness (συμμαρτυρούσης, symmartyrōusēs) with the word for conscience (συνειδήσεως, syneidēseōs) plus the accuse and defend pairing

supplies the inward law-court this lens needs, and Romans 1:19-20 supplies the creation-witness that renders all without excuse (ἀναπολογήτους, *anapologētois*).

covenant_theology: affirms · Reads the work of the law written on the heart in Romans 2:15 as a creation-order residue surviving the Fall, with conscience as its damaged but persistent register, harmonized with later covenant inscription language. On this lens the verdict is unaffected because the term-level witness is intact regardless of how the heart-writing is dated.

dispensationalism: affirms · Treats Gentile conscience in Romans 2 as a distinct moral economy under which non-Mosaic humanity is judged. The lexical witness pattern is read the same way, so the verdict is shared even where the framework differs on covenantal arc.

reliability-skeptical reading: affirms-with-scope-limit · A reader who stresses 1 Corinthians 8:7 (weak), 1 Timothy 4:2 (seared), and Titus 1:15 (defiled) grants that conscience witnesses but denies it is an infallible guide, since the canon shows the same faculty can be miscalibrated or silenced. This reading is fully compatible with the proposition, which itself says the witness is damaged by sin. It limits the scope of conscience as a rule, not whether it bears witness.

The frameworks converge on the affirms verdict because the witness function is fixed at the level of grammar and recurring vocabulary rather than at the level of any framework. They diverge only on the reliability and scope of the witness, which the words address by qualifying conscience as good, weak, seared, defiled, or cleansed, never by denying that it testifies.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The proposition describes the lexical phenomenon (internal witness, accuses or excuses, damaged by sin, renders without excuse) using terms drawn directly from Romans 2:14-15 (co-witness συμμαρτυρέω *symmartyreō*, accuse κατηγορέω *katēgoreō*, defend ἀπολογέομαι *apologeomai*) and Romans 1:20 (without-excuse ἀναπολόγητος *anapologētos*), so no tradition-laden framing is smuggled in. VERDICT-CHANGED: no. Verdict and confidence are unchanged from the prior file after direct querying of the lexical store confirmed every count and construction; the only structured corrections were the occurrence figure for conscience (συνείδησις, *syneidēsis*), since the queried STEP Bible-TAGNT (the STEP Bible Tagged Greek New Testament dataset) count is 28 distinct verses rather than 31, the cross-reference source (the graph carries these as OpenBible with real vote counts, not TSK, the Treasury of Scripture Knowledge, with one vote each), and the removal of a Romans 1:20 to Romans 16:26 link that does not exist in the cross-reference graph.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
lexicon	STEPBible-TFLSJ	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4893
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4828
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0379
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Rom.2.15
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Rom.9.1
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Rom.1.20
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Tim.4.2
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Heb.9.14
morphology	STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Job.27.6
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Rom.1.20
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Rom.2.15
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Heb.9.14

License audit

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Flags

(none)